

No. 40 The lessons from the brazen heist at the Louvre

Museum thefts are surprisingly common

Before Reading

Activity :

-What do you think a national crown-jewels collection might include, and why would it be important to protect it?

-How would you feel if a famous museum you've learned about or visited was targeted by thieves? What kinds of precautions would you expect the museum to have?

-If a museum is open to the public, what are some challenges in keeping artworks and jewelry safe without making visitors feel unwelcome or restricted?



It took two masked thieves just seven minutes to slip through the window of the Galerie d'Apollon, **pierce** the **security** glass of two display **cabinets** using disc-cutters, and **make off** with nine items of Napoleonic and royal jewellery. At 9.30am

on October 19th the pair used a truck-mounted ladder to break in to the Louvre; they left the same way, before escaping on scooters with two **accomplices**. In their haste they dropped one **looted** piece.

The **raid** strikes at the heart of the French state—and of the art world. With nearly 9m visitors in 2024, the Louvre is the most popular museum anywhere. A former royal palace in the historic centre of Paris, it is made up of over 400 galleries, displaying 35,000 works of art. Spanning civilisations from Mesopotamia to Europe, the collection also links France's royal and **imperial** past with its republican present. President Emmanuel Macron called the **heist** an attack on "our history".



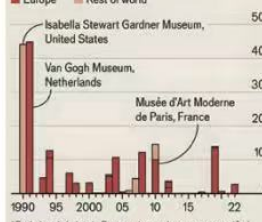
The eight items seized, worth €88m (\$102m) according to French officials, were part of the national collection of crown jewels. Kept in the museum's most **sumptuous** gallery, they include the **emerald-studded** necklace and earrings

given by Napoleon to Marie-Louise on their wedding in 1810, and a **tiara** made up of 212 pearls, 1,998 diamonds and 992 rose-cut diamonds belonging to the Empress Eugénie, Napoleon III's wife. The thieves bagged an earring, necklace and tiara from the **sapphire** collection.

Quite a loot

Art heists, value of targeted items, €m

■ Europe ■ Rest of world



*Excludes six heists in Europe where value was not specified
Source: 'The science of art theft: Using data to identify criminal patterns, 1990-2022', Cambridge University Press

The Louvre has been targeted before—most famously in 1911, when the "Mona Lisa" was stolen—but not on this scale. Arthur Brand, a Dutch specialist in art theft, compares the heist to the **snatching** of 13 works of art, including Vermeer's "The Concert" and Rembrandt's "Christ in the Storm on the Sea of Galilee", from the Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum in Boston in 1990. The following year an even more **audacious** attempt was made in Amsterdam.

Criminals made off with 20 paintings, including Van Gogh's "The Potato Eaters", though the artworks were soon recovered. But "The

Louvre is the ultimate heist," says Mr Brand. "Nobody thought anybody would dare to steal from the Louvre." The **brazenness** is worthy of a Hollywood script. Indeed in "Lupin", a hit French crime series, the **protagonist pinches** from the museum a diamond necklace once owned by Marie Antoinette.

In reality, museum theft is surprisingly common. France has seen a number of recent heists from smaller museums. An **analysis** of 40 cases between 1990 and 2022 by Sandra Clopés and Marc Balcells, published in April, **classifies** five main types of raid. The most common, accounting for 15 of the heists, is a **stealth** raid: thieves make off with artworks without **alerting** security agents. "Smash-and-grab" raids are the second-most common, **accounting** for 11 of those analysed. Over half the items taken are paintings; only 4% are jewellery. Less than half are recovered. The Louvre thieves, says an art valuer in Paris, will try to **dismantle** the pieces, sell the gold and **recut** the **precious** stones. There is no market, he says, for the items themselves.



In Paris, minds are now focusing on what went wrong and how to stop it happening again. Gérald Darmanin, the justice minister, said the raid had given France "a **dreadful** image". That a truck

could be parked outside the Louvre on a busy street on a Sunday morning without raising **suspicion** is worrying enough; that the thieves could decamp with crown jewels despite setting off alarms poses serious questions about the museum's security.

The "trick is to slow thieves down", says Mr Brand. In most cases, note Ms Clopés and Mr Balcells, "Thieves were faster stealing the pieces than the **sensors** alerting security forces." In a leaked report, France's national **auditor** points to "**persistent**" delays in **deploying** modern security equipment in the Louvre. Laurence des Cars, the museum's director, raised the problem when she took over in 2021. But, as in all public museums, budgets are tight. Rachida Dati, France's culture minister, talked this week of "40 years of **neglect**". Nobody wants to accept responsibility, but the political pressure is rising for a head to roll.

Discussion Questions:

- 1: Why might high-value items like crown jewels be a tempting target for thieves, and what makes them hard to recover once stolen?
- 2: What are some challenges museums face in balancing security with being welcoming to visitors, and what could be done to improve protection without making museums feel unwelcome?
- 3: After a museum heist, why is it important to publicly communicate about the incident, and what responsibilities do museum leaders have?